

Your assigned reading is only pgs.
222–232; however, the entire
chapter is provided for those
interested.

Please note: “ghinnawa” means a
short poem, recited or sung.

7

MODESTY AND THE POETRY OF LOVE

Discourses on Love

Personal relationships, especially love relationships with persons of the opposite sex, are of great concern among the Bedouins. Indeed, they are central to the ideology of honor and modesty: love relationships pose such a threat to the system that they are the object of stringent control through symbolic manipulation. The threat of sexuality is contained primarily by transmuting it into an element of the code of morality by which individual worth is judged. Modesty, including the denial of attachment to unrelated members of the opposite sex, is construed as a moral virtue—for women, the ultimate one. Denial of sexuality is interpreted as an aspect of self-mastery and deference to those who represent the social order. Women’s closer “natural” association with sexuality saddles them with a greater need to distance themselves from it in order to gain respectability, but men, too, must deny their sexual interests if they are to assert their autonomy.

Love relationships are also central to poetic life. As noted in chapter 5, Awlad ‘Ali associate the ghinnāwa more closely with romantic love than with any other theme.¹ But poetry is a lan-

guage of love distinct from and opposed to ordinary discourse on such matters. The same pattern of contradictory responses that characterizes individuals' responses to loss may also be seen in their communications about love relationships. In matters of love, instead of an honorable discourse of anger counterposed to a poetic discourse of vulnerability, there is a modest discourse of detachment balanced by a poetic discourse of attachment and deep feeling. This dichotomy can be seen in the way people respond to situations of thwarted love, arranged marriages, divorces, and polygynous marriages.

Star-Crossed Lovers

Ghinnāwas are tied up with the popular cultural theme of thwarted love, both in its ordinary and in its mythic manifestations. The real trials of individual sweethearts and the mythic ones of the tragic heroes and heroines of Bedouin traditional romances or love stories usually display a tension between the wishes of individual lovers and the demands of a system that is based on kinship, arranged marriage, and the priority of patrilineal parallel cousins. *Ghinnāwas* are also indexically linked to romantic love, in that sweethearts exchange poems when together (although this practice was more common in the past), and when separated they sing plaintive songs to express their longing. In Bedouin romances, lovers always speak to each other in poetry.

Although Awlad 'Ali give families the unquestioned right to arrange marriages for their children, this system, like all others, has its costs. Many arranged marriages are long-lasting and not unhappy, benefiting from luck, personal maturity, support by both kin groups, preexisting bonds of affinity or kinship, and minimal demands on or expectations of the conjugal pair. Other such marriages bring only misery.

Misery arises when one partner has an aversion to the person chosen for him or her, or had wished to marry someone else and was prevented. Nāfla's marital history, presented in chapter 3 to illustrate the limits of coercion, includes several cases of aversion. In the first arranged marriage to her cousin, she already knew the groom, had no desire to marry him, and resisted successfully. In the second one, her aversion arose as soon as she saw the groom on her wedding day. This type of aversion is so common, especially for women, who tend to have less say in their marriages, that it goes by a special term with ritualized behavioral correlates. If the girl's family refuses to support her in her bid for a divorce or the husband's family refuses to grant a divorce, the couple lives unhappily.

It often happens that one of the marriage partners is unhappy with an arranged marriage because there was someone else who would have been preferred. With the decreasing opportunity for contact between adolescent girls and boys, except in the large towns where they attend school together, this may be less of a problem now than in the past. At least according to informants' tales romances and infatuations used to be prevalent. The ideal romance was secret, involving brief meetings in isolated spots, the exchange of tokens such as jewelry or other personal possessions, and most of all, the exchange of poetry.

Romances were unlikely to result in marriage for a number of reasons. Love matches are opposed in principle; they violate the ideal of family control over marriage and represent individual initiative and hence defiance of the system. To accept love matches would be to legitimize as a force in social life passion that does not derive from relationships of kinship. One man argued that romances could lead to marriage only if the couple was careful not to let anyone, especially the girl's kin, even suspect that the two knew each other and then finagled to have the families arrange the marriage. That senior men disapprove is understandable, but even women share these views. They rationalize their disapproval by claiming that love matches never work out because if a woman

marries for love she is especially vulnerable to her husband; a woman following her heart probably does so at the expense of her kin group, so, alone in her marital community and without the support of her kin, she has no recourse if mistreated nor any leverage in asserting her rights.

The person most responsible for preventing love matches is the girl's paternal first cousin. By stepping in and claiming her for himself, a right given him by custom, he dashes any hopes a potential rival might entertain. Sometimes his claim is underpinned by a genuine wish to marry the girl; often he is put up to it by his kinsmen or does it to preserve the kin group's honor, which is threatened by the "shameful" desires of an immodest kinswoman. This threat to the authority of kinsmen is the crux of the problem with romance.

Cousins regularly avail themselves of their right, as endless stories, fictional and real, of star-crossed lovers and thwarted love matches attest. Many men complained that they had been prevented at varying stages of the negotiations from marrying women by cousins' interference, and many women were married to their cousins. The Haj, for example, had fallen in love with and wanted to marry three women before his present wife, but he had been prevented in each case by the girls' cousins. He had had his first romance at the age of seventeen; his telling of the story is intriguing because he mentions the role poetry played in it. He and his father took considerable pride in this defiant romance, a significant fact but one that I will wait until the final chapter to discuss; here I will only note that people enforced the social system and thwarted those who tried to contravene it. I paraphrase his story as he told it:

It was 1950. I was in love with a girl from a Mrâbiṭ tribe. Her father and mine were best friends. She was tough but beautiful. I loved her and she loved me. We would arrange meetings through friends, who took messages back and forth. We only managed meetings of a few minutes. We

recited poetry to one another. I never touched her; we met just to talk. I swear it was not for anything else. We are humans, not animals. This was God-given love [*min rabnā*], true love.

One day, after much scheming, we managed to arrange a special rendezvous. We were out in the desert, far away from the camps. We sat together, she a few inches away [a respectable distance], and I had my rifle across my lap. Suddenly her three cousins [father's brother's sons] came upon us. [How did they know about the meeting?] They had been keeping an eye on her.

She nearly died of fear. She knew they would kill her, or kill me. But I had a gun and they didn't. I asked her, "Would you feel safe if you were in your father's house?" She said yes. So we got up and I slowly walked her toward her camp. The three cousins walked near us, watching every move. But I delivered her safely to her father's house and had to explain everything to her father.

Her father came to see mine, told him everything that had happened. It was a big scandal. But my father was very fond of me, and her father was fond of her. He said he would be willing to give his daughter to us [in marriage]. My father was willing to pay the bride-price. No one had ever gotten away with something like this before, but they all respected me for not having run, for having bravely walked the girl home to protect her. It showed I was a real man.

But her (cousins) prevented the marriage. They called a tribal hearing [*mi'ad*] to settle the problem. The conditions set were that I was never to see or talk to her again. They said I must never try to get in touch with her. Then one of these cousins married her. When he died, another of the cousins married her. She is still living with him. Her husband is now a friend of mine, so I occasionally see her. I greet her when I go to their house [a sign of familiarity].

It is all over now, even the feelings. But it lasted a long time. I was very sad at the time. My father used to ask people to recite the many poems I had composed for her and

her responses because they were so beautiful.² I married very late. I was thirty. This was because the same thing kept happening. It happened again twice. I loved someone and she loved me but it was not destined to be [*naṣīb*]. Each time, the cousins of the girl prevented the marriage. Finally I gave up and was willing to take any old wife.

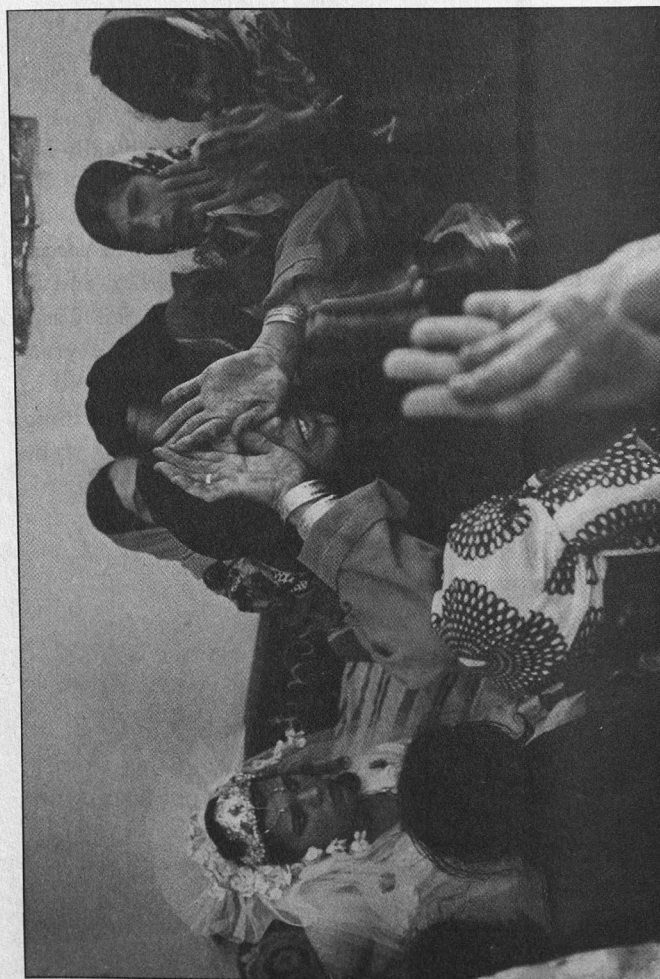
Proud of his poetic skills, one day the Haj offered to record some *ghinnāwas* for me. We went over the tape together, and he gave exegeses of the twelve poems he had sung. The first was a poem he had composed about the Mrābiṭ girl, a couple of years after she had married her cousin. He explained that it referred to his despair at never being able to have her and at having nothing left of her but memories. When he thought of her, he fell ill, so he wished he could just forget her.

Thinking of them with pain
if only they would not come to mind . . .
tafākīrhun bawjā'
lū kān mā 'alēnā yukhuṭrū . . .

A second poem was about a married woman he had loved. It describes the strain of trying to catch a glimpse of her from a distance, she who wasn't free to meet him. The word he uses for married woman is common to this genre, although not used in the vernacular. It comes from the same root as *hostage*.

They've worn you out, oh eye
married loved ones with no time for you . . .
mdhāyblīnik yā 'ēn
awlāfun mrāhīn mā fdhaw . . .

Poetry, from this case, is clearly the medium through which sentiments of love and longing are expressed.



*The groom's female relatives
dance and sing to welcome
a new bride*

An Arranged Marriage

Most people lead less dramatic lives; most do not pine away for those forbidden to them, and most do not die of broken hearts. People nevertheless confront difficult personal situations, which are often the consequence of the way Bedouin society structures the relations between men and women.

The complex relationship between poetry and the discourse of everyday life is reflected in the reactions of Fāyga, a young woman of about twenty-five, to her arranged marriage to a man in our community. By juxtaposing her poetic and mundane responses we can see how she grappled with conflicting feelings and motivations. Paramount in ordinary social interactions was her concern not to compromise her image as a proper Bedouin girl from a good family who knows the meaning of *hasham*—in both its senses, as sexual modesty and as propriety. As a good woman she should not resist a marriage arranged by her brothers, as this would constitute defiance. At the same time, she should express no interest in men, not even her husband, in order to preserve her image as sexually modest. She upheld these standards in her interactions with others in her husband's household and in her conversations with me. But in her poems, especially those she recited in the first months of her marriage, she revealed shifting feelings about the marriage, feelings very different from the ones she conveyed in her public response.

Fāyga was brought as a bride for the Haj's brother Rashīd, the man whose first wife's angry reaction I described in the last chapter. He had decided to take a second wife—perhaps because his first wife, Mabrukā, kept giving birth to sickly children—and had heard about Fāyga from a friend. As an adult, he had arranged for the marriage himself, using his friend as a go-between. Although he claimed that he had seen her before the wedding, she insisted that she had not seen him. She and her mother had been living in a household with her older brothers, her guardians in her father's absence, who were responsible for agreeing to the marriage. Be-

cause there had been no previous marriages between her family and Rashīd's, and because both Fāyga and Rashīd were of high-status families that were unrelated, the negotiations had been long and the bride-price was high. There was a big wedding.

Things seemed all right at first. Fāyga, who did not know any of the women in her husband's community, was initially shy; she rarely talked, and she ate little during the first week or two. This was normal—strangers are expected to feel uncomfortable and to *tahashsham*. The women who lived in her household, her sisters-in-law, and visiting women teased her continually about sexual matters, loading their conversations with innuendos about her marital pleasures. She persistently feigned ignorance and innocence, denying any comprehension of what the women meant. They found her insistence a bit annoying, in part because it showed how estranged she felt among them, but they also recognized that they should respect her for it since she did it out of sexual modesty.

About two weeks after the wedding we had the first hints that she was unhappy with her marriage. She framed her dissatisfaction in terms that would reinforce her image as uninterested in men and sex and devoted to her kin group. She scolded the girls one night for singing wedding songs, saying, "It is wrong to sing and dance for the bride on the night before her wedding. What are people celebrating? Her separation from her loved ones?" I do not know what happened over the next three weeks, because I left for a short trip, but when I returned her attitude had worsened noticeably. One day she just started crying, allegedly because she missed her relatives. Two days later she confided in her mother-in-law that she was *zāhda* (had an aversion to her husband). That night, she stayed up late talking to the women, stubbornly ignoring their pleas to go to her room, where, as she well knew, her husband sat waiting for her. She dragged her heels night after night.

One afternoon she promised to help me interpret some wed-

ding *ghinnāwas*, so I sat with her in her room. After a bit she began reciting new poems and songs. First she sang a long song, the gist of which was that sharing a husband was not good. Then came a short poem that seemed more like a proverb. It was on the same theme of the undesirability of polygyny:

(Better death, blindness, poverty, and destitution
than a match with a married man . . .
il-mōt wil-'ama wil-fagr
wil-'āza wlā šōb il-ghanī . . .

She then recited a series of *ghinnāwas* on the theme of one's divine lot, or fate in life. When I asked at one point if a particular poem was about herself, she laughed and said it was just a song. Then she asked if it was important that it be about herself and admitted, "Yes, even this one is about me." These poems seemed to express her dissatisfaction with the marriage that had been arranged for her. In the first she suggests agitation about something that could not be helped—presumably her choice of marriage partner:

You want, oh dear one, to be disappointed
and to fight about something not fated to be . . .
trīd yā 'azīz tkhīb
wt'ārik 'alē shī mā gsim . . .

In the second, she implies that her lot is so bad she would not wish it on a friend:

Without pleasures is my lot
oh God, may it not be imposed on a friend . . .
gsāmī blā ghayyāt
liṣ-ṣāhib allāh lā yjībhun . . .

She explained the third as being about someone who wanted something she did not get. When I questioned her, she admitted that she had wanted to marry another man.

Don't blame those who hurt you
just say it was not meant to be . . .

mā min illī yā 'ēn
ijrahik ghēr gūlī mā gsimsh . . .

A few days later her brother-in-law, sister-in-law, and I set off to take her on a formal visit to her father.³ It was a difficult trip, taking us far into the desert where we had trouble finding our way and were caught in a sandstorm. We didn't stay long because her brother-in-law was anxious to return. Fāyga was disappointed; she wanted to wait to see her younger brother, who had just been released from jail and was supposed to be on his way to her father's. When we got home she said she was ill and complained that they could have dropped her off at her mother's, where her brother was sure to come next.

After we returned from this trip she began to find fault with everything about her husband's kin group. She complained to me and to the girls in the group that the men neglected and overworked their women and children and that their lifestyle was appalling and unlike what she, coming from a town, was accustomed to. It is unclear whether by this she hoped merely to insult them or, more seriously, to provoke their anger so they would wish to send her home. She also began to recite a great deal of poetry that struck me as more negative than her earlier poems. The first poem she recited after her return was very depressing:

On my breast I placed
a tombstone, though I was not dead, oh loved one . . .

'alē šidērī ḥaṭṭēt
shahāyid blā mōt yā 'alam . . .

Modesty and the Poetry of Love

The next day she recited a couple of poems, which I later shared with several women who interpreted them as indicating unhappiness with the marriage and a desire to end it. They suspected that Fāyga wished to marry someone else. The poems were the following:

Can it be that the eye would not want
to be happy again and its condition to clear . . .

z'ama mā trīd il-'ēn
tazhā jdīd wyrūg ḥālhā . . .

If a new love match is not granted
the ache in my mind will continue, oh beloved . . .

in mā jdā šōb jdīd
šudā' l-'agl mā zāl yā 'alam . . .

When I questioned her privately about these poems and her feelings about her marriage, she at first protested that she was unhappy because she found her husband ugly and old. (He was neither.) In a conversation a few days later, rather than mentioning a desire for another man—which she had all but admitted earlier in her poems and in her explanations of them—she took a different approach. She presented herself as a modest and asexual woman, professing a horror of sex, and as a good Bedouin with close ties to kin and a devotion to Islam. She said she wanted to have nothing to do with marriage.

I don't like being married. I don't like men. I want to go home to my family and just live there forever. It is much better to live without a man. What good is marriage? [Do you hate all men?] No, just a man who would want to "take me" [sexually]. I did not want to marry. Many people came to ask for me, but I refused to marry. I just wanted to stay with my relatives, those dear to me. I want to pray and go on the pilgrimage. And my brother's children, I adore them.

I practically raised them. What is this marriage stuff, away from your dear ones and you can't even go to visit them. Men, I never liked them. I'm afraid of them and I am disgusted by them [*nitgarraf minhum*]. [How did you feel on your wedding night?] I was afraid and so embarrassed. Oh, I got so embarrassed [*kisift*] and disgusted. I felt sick. I couldn't eat. The whole first week I was disgusted and embarrassed. No, I want to go back home and never marry again.

Two days later she ran away, causing quite a stir in the community and considerable concern and speculation about her motives. The reactions of some individuals have already been described in chapter 3, referring to the unmanly way her husband, Rashīd, reacted. Fāyga was eventually persuaded to return, following negotiations and the rumored use of force by her brothers and intimidation by her mother.

Fāyga never gave a straight answer to the question of why she had left. When she did not answer, "Just because . . .," she insisted that her husband had suddenly looked like an evil spirit and she had fled in fright. People privately proposed a number of theories. Some said that she was merely playing hard-to-get to raise herself in her husband's esteem and to secure a place in his affections; they assumed that she wished to displace her senior co-wife. Others thought she had left because she was jealous of his senior wife. Still others suspected sorcery or magic. There seemed to be no way to choose among the hypotheses.

Through her poems, though, what people took to be the truth came out. After her return, she complained often of illness, stubbornly defended her act to all the women who pressed and scolded her, and recited or sang many *ghinnāwas*. Nearly all her poems revolved around themes of putting up with bad luck and of suffering from longing for something unattainable. For the only time, I broke my promise not to reveal any of the women's poems to

men and shared some of them with her brother-in-law, who was extremely puzzled about the true state of her feelings. I had confided that she had recited some poems to me, and he begged to hear them. He listened intently and was astounded. A backer of the theory that she was merely playing games to maneuver for a better position, he changed his mind when he heard the poems, commenting as he listened, "It's really that bad! I had not realized. She really is upset."

When I shared yet others with my closest confidantes, they confirmed that not only was she miserable, but she probably was also in love with another man. I confronted her, and she defensively asked who had told me. I pretended I had figured it out from her poems, and then she confessed that she had wanted to marry a man from another tribe, whose marriage offer her brothers had refused because of a history of hostility between the families. She said she had not really known him but had fallen in love because she heard he was young, handsome, and wealthy.

A few basic points about the use of poetry in social life can be drawn even from this fragment of a young woman's reaction to an arranged marriage. *Ghinnāwas* seem to have been the medium in which she could voice responses not culturally appropriate for a young Bedouin woman. Acquiescence to the decisions of her brothers and kinsmen, especially regarding her marriage, was proper. Respectability required the denial of romantic love or any interest in such matters. She tried to follow the correct path, or at least to present herself as conforming to these ideals. Even when she ran away, she tried to follow the customary procedure for declaring her unhappiness. But in her poems, which increased in frequency and intensity as she became more unhappy, she expressed a different set of sentiments and presented a side of her feelings not revealed elsewhere. More intriguing than the fact that she used poetry to express such sentiments was the fact that others judged that the poems reflected her reactions more accurately and dependably than did her ordinary behavior and conversation.

Marriage, Divorce, and Polygyny

The loves of youth, fulfilled or unfulfilled, pass. Individuals have to face different kinds of crises in love once they have married, settled down, and begun their adult lives. Most Awlad 'Ali marry fairly young—girls between about fifteen and twenty, boys anywhere between sixteen and thirty, depending on their financial situations. Many first marriages do not last but break up within a few months to a year because of youthful incompatibility or in-law difficulties; most people remain with their second partners.

The behavior and attitudes of spouses toward one another are powerfully shaped by the cultural ideals of modesty. Even if over time a married couple develop attachments, they rarely display their affection publicly. They spend little time together and do not engage in extended conversation, share meals, or work side by side. They politely avoid talking about each other in conversations with others, and they do not utter each other's names. When men and women do make statements about their spouses or their marriages, they tend to express a limited range and special type of sentiment. At best they offer protestations of indifference or assertions of emotional independence. Women make jokes to suggest detachment from and lack of interest in their husbands. In situations of marital conflict, hostile insults and bitter complaints do surface, but these are always couched in material rather than emotional terms and justified by appeals to rights and duties.

Others reinforce these standards partly through teasing. I was surprised by the reception given a young woman who came running to one household crying. Shortly before, her husband had decided to take her back after "leaving" her (no longer going to sleep in her room) for two years. Now he was giving her a hard time about her chickens, which he said were messing the house; he wanted her to get rid of them. But she had been raising them for years and had used them to support her children. The women to whom she complained all concurred with one old woman who

asked, "Why did you agree to go back to him? What do you want with a man? Your chickens are worth more than a husband."

It is especially improper for an older woman to complain about losing her husband as a sexual partner. Some men argued that older couples should be like brother and sister; women thought it was "a shame in the woman's face" (*'ēb fī wījh il-wliyya*) to have sexual relations with her husband once her children were grown. One woman in our community was highly regarded for her calm response when her husband abandoned her for his second wife. Another woman, whose story will be told below, encountered criticism for admitting desire for her estranged husband.

The attachment and emotional dependence that often develop despite social and cultural deemphasis of, even disdain for, emotional closeness between husband and wife are uncovered, at least in poetry, when the relationship is threatened. Divorce can be a critical event in people's lives. In the first few years of a marriage or before there are children, divorce, instigated by either husband or wife, rarely induces anguish. The woman returns to her family and nearly always remarries shortly thereafter. Little stigma attaches to divorce, and divorcées often command high bride-prices. Over a third of the adults in my community had been officially divorced at least once.⁴

But when divorce occurs after many years of marriage, it can be quite difficult. By this time a woman usually has many children and is unlikely to ask for a divorce, even if she is abused or unhappy, because she would have to leave her children behind, something most women cannot bear. Most commonly, then, at this stage in a marriage, a husband will divorce his wife after marital disputes or will "leave" her in favor of a younger wife. The wife has two choices in such situations: to return to her kin or to remain with her children. She often decides to stay with her children, and the husband is then responsible for providing her with food, clothing, and shelter. In the case of an angry divorce, they spend no time together and do not even greet one another in the camp. In a more friendly divorce or when the husband

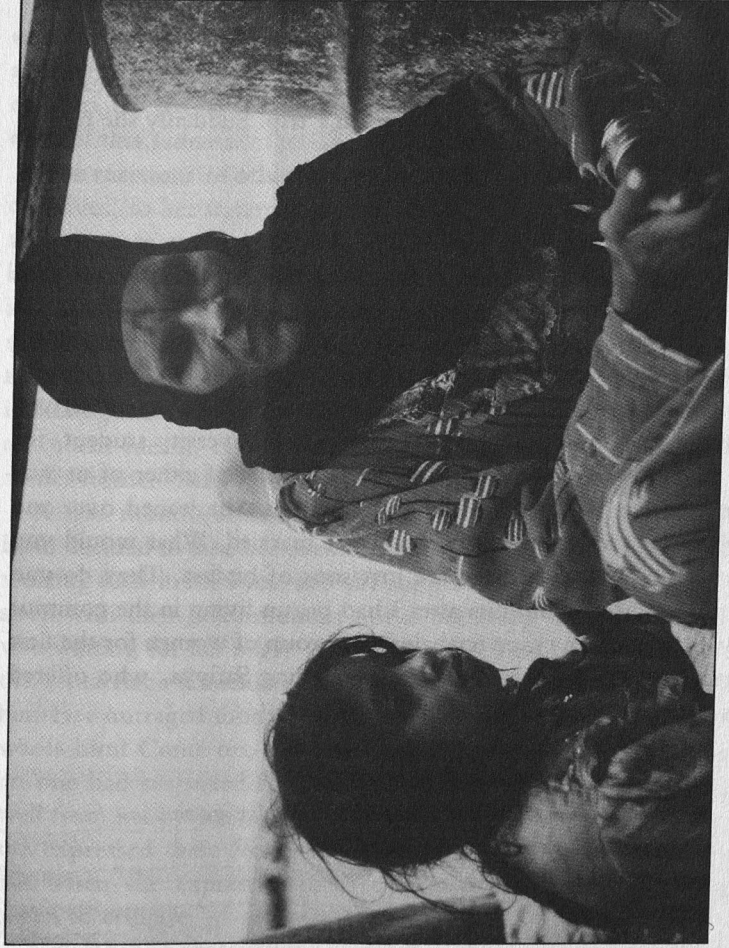
"leaves" the older woman (usually a first cousin) for a junior wife, the senior woman retains her position as head of the domestic household and continues to discuss business with her ex-husband, keep charge of his money, and share in confidential matters.

Şafiyya's case illustrates the devastating personal effect of a divorce not wished for and the social and cultural pressure not to admit the pain. More important, her dual response to the divorce, in ordinary social interactions on the one hand and in poetry on the other, and the reactions of members of her community to these divergent expressions reveal something critical about the *ghinnāwa*'s role in social life.

One day this woman of about forty told me about her divorce. The event she described had occurred a year before I arrived in the camp where she had spent the twenty years of her married life. She said:

My youngest daughter was nursing in my arms when he left me. I was sick and tired. "The man" came up to me one afternoon as I sat by the oven. He said, "You're divorced." I said, "Thanks, that's just fine by me." He said, "You can go home to your relatives now." I answered, "And leave my daughters here to be servants to the other women? No. I'll stay here with my children." For a year and a half we did not speak to each other. Now we greet each other. I didn't want him. I don't want anything from him except to build me a house to live in with my son—a place where I can feel at home. I didn't care when he divorced me. I never liked him. He had taken another wife, but that didn't bother me. I never fought with her. Why should I? These things don't bother us.

This statement did not surprise me. Its tone of aggressive non-chalance was consistent with that expressed by other men and women when they talked about their marriages, even those uncomplicated by divorce or polygyny. As we saw in the last chapter, this type of emotional response to painful situations is characteristic.



Mother and daughter

Veiled Sentiments

Yet, two days later, we were sitting with several other women in her household, chatting during a lull in the busy round of domestic activities, when conversation turned to the whereabouts of her ex-husband, who was away on a trip. Suddenly she recited a short poem:

Memories stirred of the beloved
should I release, I'm flooded by them . . .

khaṭarhā sirīb 'azīz
kēf nashā nsīl bi . . .

I remembered the first time I had met Ṣafiyya. I had arrived with another young woman, an Egyptian university student, for my first visit to the camp. Ṣafiyya had asked if either of us was married. We both replied in the negative. She leaned over and advised us earnestly, "Don't ever get married. What would you want with marriage? Men are just sons of bitches. They do you no good." A few months after I had begun living in the community, I showed my tape recorder to a group of women for the first time. Some volunteered to sing, including Ṣafiyya, who offered this song:

((Oh eyes be strong
you cherish people and then they're gone . . .
yā nzār dīrun 'azm
tghālī 'arab wyfārgū . . .

There was no doubt in the minds of all who subsequently heard this song on tape that it referred to her ex-husband.

The incongruity between what Ṣafiyya said in ordinary language and what she expressed in poetry is striking. Her ordinary statements alternated between denials of concern about her loss and her husband's rejection and expressions of bitterness and anger. Yet both of her poems convey the impression of sadness.

The tears connoted by images of flooding and the reference to eyes are indices of sadness and suffering. The warnings to herself about the consequences of letting go and the exhortation to her eyes to be strong suggest the vigilance and effort required to control this sadness.

The reactions of other women in the community, including her co-wives, to her statements, both poetic and nonpoetic, give valuable clues to the functions of *ghinnāwas*. The taped song elicited both the nervous joking of people embarrassed by a display of immodesty and the sympathetic noises of people who cared, understood her situation, and were moved by her recitation. She had recited the other poem in the presence of a number of women, including her co-wives, who said nothing. When I asked her what the poem meant, one co-wife joked, "Go ask 'the man' when he comes home." Şafiyya begged me not to.

A few months after my conversation with her, Şafiyya's husband decided to take her back. She suddenly began to dress nicely, wearing *kuhl* in her eyes, and she suggested that her older children sleep with their grandmother, not in her room. She joked that she was waiting for her *nugūt* (wedding gifts). Her blatant pleasure at the remarriage scandalized everyone. People gossiped and teased her. Her outraged mother-in-law exclaimed, "She wants him, she wants him! Come on, her son is already a man!" It was not as if no one had suspected her feelings—these women knew perfectly well from her poems how attached she was to the man. As long as she expressed these feelings in *ghinnāwas*, they had sympathized; but when she expressed them openly, outside of poetry, they began to criticize.

A number of observations about the role of poetry in matters of the heart can be drawn from this case. Sentiments of attachment to a loved one that violate the moral code, which for women centers on sexual modesty, find expression in poetry. For the most part, these poetic revelations are contradicted by public protestations of indifference and denials of attachment congruent with the cultural ideology about sexual love. When individuals slip and convey mes-

sages in the inappropriate medium, sharp criticism alerts them to their transgression, thus reinforcing the system.

The same pattern of divergent discourses on love is apparent in the responses of another woman, whose husband took a second wife. Like divorce, polygyny can be a source of anguish for Bedouin women, but concern over loss of the husband's affection is similarly considered culturally inappropriate and personally immodest.

Polygyny among Awlad 'Ali is on the increase thanks to the influx of wealth from smuggling, the skyrocketing value of their traditional lands along the Mediterranean coast, and other economic developments. I gathered from discussions with the older members of the community that in former generations, rather than put up with a co-wife, women were more likely to divorce their husbands or make life so difficult that their husbands would be dissuaded from remarrying. Now other women scold and mollify first wives with such statements as, "Are you the only one this has ever happened to? These days it is to be expected. It happens to everyone." Women joke that only the poor have their husbands to themselves because these men cannot afford second wives. In the community I lived in, over a third of the men married longer than two years had more than one wife. The correlation between wealth and polygyny is clear; only one of these men was not from the wealthy core families.

Reactions to a husband's second or third marriage vary. In some cases, especially when the senior wife has been consulted or has approved or even chosen the new wife, things go smoothly. People could always point to examples of households in which co-wives were "like sisters." My community had several such pairs of cooperative co-wives who rarely fought and appeared to be close and inseparable companions. In many other cases, however, women meet the news of their husband's decision to take a second wife with less equanimity, and relations between co-wives are often strained or volatile.

In addition to social pressure against displaying negative responses to the prospect of sharing a husband, internal pressures

for comportment in terms of sexual modesty determine many women's public responses in this trying situation. The concern to convey indifference to the loss of the husband's affections underlay the response of one woman whose husband was about to take another wife. One day he accused her of having stolen a ten-pound note that was missing from his pocket (he later found the note in another pocket). She was hurt by the false accusation and angry, but rather than going home to her kin in anger, as she might have done under ordinary circumstances, she forced herself to stay. She worried that people would misconstrue her motives and assume that she had left because of the husband's upcoming marriage, not the false accusation. In households where polygyny is already a fact, women often take the offensive, seizing on violations of their rights to validate displeasure. An unhappy wife can always find some infraction on which to hang her complaints, because polygyny is clearly regulated in Bedouin society; the requirement that a husband treat his wives equally, from following a strict nightly rotation to bringing each identical gifts, right down to every bar of soap, opens vast possibilities for grievances.

And yet, if women feel compelled in mundane social interactions to mask overt signs of jealousy or feelings of betrayal—indicators of affection toward and attachment to their husbands—they can and do express those sentiments in poetry. The following case illustrates the relationship between poetic and ordinary statements about the loss of a husband's affections, focusing specifically on the portrayal of indifference in ordinary discourse, rather than its alternative, anger.

In our first conversation after she heard the news that her husband of sixteen years was going to take a second wife, Mabrūka, Rashīd's wife and mother of his six children, complained that her husband never bought her nice things for her room. She denied, however, that the upcoming marriage bothered her. She asserted, "Let him get married, I don't care. But he should buy me nice things. He's worthless, he always was. A real man asks after his family, sees to it that they have everything they need."

As the wedding arrangements proceeded, problems arose. In the last chapter I described Mabrūka's angry response on discovering that the gifts her husband had offered her were not equivalent to the ones he had brought the bride, and her subsequent rejection of the gifts. I also presented some of the sad poems she recited, poems that carried messages of attachment to her husband and a sense of abandonment.

Mabrūka did not attend the wedding or help with the preparations for it, as do many senior wives. When her sister arrived at the wedding and found her missing, she went to talk to her. Mabrūka calmly insisted that her help was sorely needed at the wedding of some neighbors being celebrated concurrently and that was why she hadn't gone.

When her husband spent several days more than the customary week-long honeymoon with his new bride, Mabrūka protested that she did not care. She added that she had no intention of visiting the new bride's household to welcome her, nor did she wish any visitors. A woman in her household reported that she had said, "Let him stay there." I happened to be visiting her when her husband returned for the first time in the ten days since the wedding. He came with goods from the market; she was quiet, only muttering under her breath about what he had failed to buy. He took his gun to go hunting, and as he walked away, she commented to me, "It's been ages [literally, years] since we saw him." I asked sympathetically if she missed him. She replied abruptly, "No way. Do you think he is dear to me? I don't even ask about him. He can come and go as he pleases."

Moments later she recited a few poems. One suggested her consternation over the events of the recent past, brought up by his sudden appearance; another conveys a sense of betrayal:

They always left me
stuffed with false promises . . .

dīmā khallō l-'agl
'āmrāt bimwā'idhum . . .

In the course of this interchange Mabrukā's mother-in-law and a close woman-friend joined us. They spontaneously added to her poems, voicing what they assumed she was experiencing. These same women had previously scolded her, or teased her, for her angry reactions, but through poetry they consoled her by showing their empathic concern. For them, the poetic discourse served as a medium in which they could recognize the legitimacy of attachment to a husband. The themes common to all the poems these women recited were those of sadness, suffering, and despair. Among the poems was one that referred explicitly to polygyny, the rich man being a euphemism for a married man.

(My tears rushed down like a flood on a hill
flowing over the match of the rich man . . .
ḥdiran kēf sēl il-'ilu
dmū'ī 'ale šōb il-ghanī . . .

Another one, sung by the friend, evoked a despair so powerful it could drive someone to abandon human society and to roam outdoors like an animal.

(Despair of them, dear one, made you
a stray who wanders between watering places . . .
khalāk yāshum yā l-'ēn
ḡhulīl tdūrī 'al l-ignī . . .

As time passed, Mabrukā seemed to adjust. She still sometimes complained of illness, fevers, and bad teeth; then she had a miscarriage. She was also put in a difficult position when Fāyga ran away. But she rarely talked about her husband. She continued to recite poetry, though. The poems a few months after the marriage reflect sadness mingled with philosophical resignation to reality, as in the following:

Patience is my mourning for the loved one
and your job, oh eye, is to cry . . .

'azāy fī 'azīz iṣ-ṣabr
wintī 'alēk yā 'ēn il-bkā . . .

Another alludes to the effort it takes to control her concern:

Patience is better than thinking
if only you can manage it, oh self . . .

iṣ-ṣabr khēr min it-tafkīr
'alēh kān yā 'ēn taḡdarī . . .

These cases confirm the strong link between poetry and matters of love, romantic or conjugal, and justify us in designating the *ghinnawa* as a discourse of love. This discourse seems to be opposed to the mundane discourse of ordinary language structured by overt social values and honor-linked personal ideals. Individuals whose ordinary actions and statements conform to the modesty code, who take pains to present themselves as moral and worthy of respect, use poetry to comment on their personal fortunes and tribulations in love and to express sentiments that violate the canons of modesty. Poems are vehicles for the expression of attachments to sweethearts or spouses that, if communicated in everyday social interaction, would damage reputations and jeopardize claims to respectability and, at the individual level, would ordinarily undermine self-image and self-presentation. In the final chapter I turn to the questions raised by this observation: that contradictory discourses on love coexist, just as do the divergent discourses of honor and vulnerability explored in chapter 6.

CHAPTER SEVEN

1. Jibrīl (1973, 76), who defines the genre known in Libya as *ṣūb khalīl* by length, meter, and topic, says that all of these poems deal with some aspect of love or feelings toward the loved one. He goes too far, although there is little doubt that the *ghinnāwa* is more closely associated with love than with any other theme. Many of the examples presented in chapter 5 were love poems, and some of the cases described in chapter 6 concerned loss in love. Other examples can be found in the Appendix.

2. Because of relations of respect between father and son, sons would never sing in front of their fathers. The interest the Haj's father showed in his son's poems indicates his secret admiration for his son. Why he might have such an admiration will be explored in the final chapter.

3. It is customary to take the bride on a formal visit (called the *zawra*) to her family's house fifteen days after the wedding and to bring along some sheep for sacrifice and also perhaps tea, sugar, and flour. In this case, the groom's family had already taken her to see her brother and mother, with whom she had lived before her marriage. Then they had paid a visit to her uncles, prominent men with whom this family wished to be associated. They paid her father a special visit because he lived separate from her mother, whom he had divorced years earlier, and her brothers. (The father was last on the list because he lived furthest away.) In most cases, only one *zawra* would have sufficed, but the groom's family took advantage of the complicated residence pattern (ideally, the girl's father and uncles would have all been in one camp) to display their generosity.

4. Divorce is a complicated matter among the *ʿAwlad ʿAli*. According to Islamic law, a man can repudiate his wife by pronouncing the formula "I divorce you" three times consecutively. This, for the Bedouins, constitutes a "final" divorce, or what I have called an official divorce. The Bedouins also usually require that the husband write this formula on a piece of paper for the divorce to be recognized. After this type of divorce a husband cannot take his wife back without remarrying her formally, which he cannot do unless she marries and divorces someone else in the interim; he must also pay bride-wealth again. There are, however, nonfinal divorces, which are much more common. If the husband only says the formula once, he may take his wife back if she agrees. Many of the couples in my community had at one time been estranged in this way. In some cases, the wife returned to her family for periods ranging from two days to nine months; in other cases, she remained in

the camp. Usually the husband had to give her a gift of some jewelry or money when he decided to take her back.

CHAPTER EIGHT

1. This modesty about *ghinnāwas* even applies to wedding songs, as I discovered during a bridal procession when the wife of the man driving the car we rode in confessed her embarrassment about singing in front of her husband. This was the first time she had done so, even though they had been married nearly twenty years.

2. Turner (1976, 1008-9) argues that the difference between values and norms "is principally in the eye of the beholder. . . . The object (value) and the rule (norm) are two constructions the individual can place on the same phenomenon. Which construction is foremost in his experience makes important differences in his relationship to social structure." He goes on to argue that different conceptions of the self—in his model, self-as-impulse and self-as-institution—correspond to different experiences of these phenomena.

3. The use of a formulaic medium to express sentiments that threaten self-image may serve the individuals reciting poems as a psychological distancing mechanism, just as the identification with the experiences of others implied by the use of well-known poems to express sentiments may be psychologically reassuring in times of crisis.

4. For this reason I find Boesen's (1979/80, 238) analysis of a genre of Pashtun women's love songs (called *landai*) a bit weak. She argues that women's infidelities and the love songs that glorify them are "the individual's personal revolt against a system which denies her the right of disposing of her own body and choosing her own fate." Yet she also notes that "the 'revolt' of women does not challenge the Pashtun social code of honour as such." It seems to me that she has not considered the possibility that the messages of the love songs are somehow also part of the code, or at least culturally accepted, which indeed they must be if they are a well-known genre.

5. For a seminal discussion of the performative or illocutionary function of language, see Austin (1975).

6. Burke (1969, 50) notes this dual definition of rhetoric as that which changes attitude and/or action: "Thus the notion of persuasion to attitude would permit the application of rhetorical terms to purely *poetic* structures; the study of lyrical devices might be classed under the head of